

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN CHAD

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the lake, land, and rivers of Chad — and here the stakes are the water and food of tens of millions across four nations, in a place where the truth about the great lake is more complicated than the headlines, a giant scheme is proposed to "save" it that may do harm, and the work must be done carefully, in a poor land under military rule and touched by conflict. Chad's environmental life turns above all on Lake Chad, the great transboundary lake it shares with Nigeria, Niger, and Cameroon, on which tens of millions depend for fishing, farming, and herding. In the droughts of the 1970s and 1980s the lake shrank drastically, to less than a tenth of its former size, and became a symbol of a warming world; but the honest, more recent science is that the lake is not simply vanishing — it fluctuates with the rains, has partly recovered, and its communities have long adapted to its rising and falling. The real crisis of the Lake Chad basin is not a lake quietly disappearing but a tangle of variable water, deep poverty, and a long insurgency that has displaced millions — a tangle that no single fix can cut. Into this has come Transaqua, a vast proposal to refill the lake by diverting water from the distant Congo basin, championed by some as the only answer but warned by others to be a costly, risky scheme that could devastate the Congo basin and flood Chad's own lands. And Chad has oil, whose pipeline was once a famous experiment in turning oil money to the good of the people — an experiment that failed. This guide will be honest that the lake's story is complex and its science nuanced, that the poverty and conflict are real and beyond any easy remedy, that the nation is poor and under military rule and much of the region insecure, and that no single victory is to be won; but it will show that the levers here — the honest defence of the lake's livelihoods, the scrutiny of the grand scheme, the accountability for the oil, the transboundary frameworks, and the humanitarian stake — are real, and can be used, with care.

The Chadian story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever pressed together. The second is distinctly Chadian, and it is what gives this guide its particular force. **Because the lake's livelihoods can be defended through honest science and adaptation rather than a risky fix, because a grand scheme proposed to save the lake can and must be rigorously scrutinised, because the oil's harm and its broken promises can be held to account, because the lake and the Congo are governed by transboundary frameworks, and because the humanitarian stakes reach the whole world, the levers run through truth, scrutiny, and accountability: the lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, the oil accountability, the frameworks, and the humanitarian stake.** That combination — the lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, the oil accountability, the frameworks, and the humanitarian stake — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because in a poor, conflict-touched basin whose truth is contested, the strongest ground is honest science, the rigorous scrutiny of grand fixes, and the accountability the frameworks and the world can bring.

But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **The lake's story is complex, the poverty and conflict deep, the nation poor and troubled, and no victory is final.** The lake is not simply vanishing, and the crisis is a tangle of climate variability, poverty, and conflict, so honest science and adaptation, not a single dramatic rescue, are the realistic path; the poverty and the long insurgency are real and beyond easy remedy, and much of the region is insecure and dangerous; the nation

is poor, under military rule, and its space for open opposition narrow, so the work runs carefully through community, technical, and international channels, protecting the vulnerable; and there is no landmark victory to point to. This guide does not pretend the lake is dying on cue, or that a grand scheme will save it, or that the conditions are safe. What it shows is how, through the lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, the oil accountability, the frameworks, and the humanitarian stake, Chadians and their allies can defend the basin's livelihoods, scrutinise the destructive "solution," and hold the oil to account — carefully, honestly, within the troubled conditions that exist.

Most people who care about Chad's environment do not know HOW to use the levers a poor, contested, conflict-touched basin offers. They see the lake shrunk and swollen by turns, the grand scheme advancing, the oil's promises broken — and either accept the headline that the lake is doomed, or despair of the poverty and conflict, and rarely grasp the levers that work: the honest science of the lake, the scrutiny of the scheme, the accountability for the oil, the transboundary frameworks, the humanitarian stake. The gap between the basin's livelihoods defended and lost is here often a gap of method — the method of using the lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, the oil accountability, the frameworks, and the humanitarian stake together.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Chadian reality as it is, which is a poor, conflict-touched, military-ruled nation at the heart of a contested transboundary basin. It is written for the person — in a fishing, farming, or herding community, in Chad's technical world, or among its international partners — who sees the lake's livelihoods threatened and the grand schemes advancing and wants to know what can be done in a troubled land where the truth itself is contested. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers are real — the lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, the oil accountability, the frameworks, and the humanitarian stake — with the honest qualifiers that the lake's story is complex, the poverty and conflict deep, the nation troubled, and no victory final, so the work is careful, honest, community-and-international, protecting the vulnerable, not open confrontation. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it should be used, because the Chadian case is particular and demands both honesty and the greatest care. It is for the person — a member of a fishing, farming, or herding community, someone in Chad's technical or scientific world, or an international partner — willing to do the patient, careful, and honest work of defending the basin's livelihoods and scrutinising the grand fixes through accurate science and the world's frameworks, rather than either accepting the headline that the lake is doomed or attempting the open confrontation that a military-ruled, conflict-touched land makes both ineffective and dangerous. That is not a lesser ambition but, in Chad's conditions, the effective and responsible one, because here the levers that genuinely deliver are honest science, the livelihoods, the scrutiny of grand schemes, and the international frameworks, all of which are reached through the community and the partners rather than through confrontation, and all of which depend on getting the truth right. Anyone who approaches Chad recklessly, or on a false and dramatic story, may endanger the vulnerable and mislead the response; anyone who approaches it carefully, honestly, through the frameworks and the community and with the safety of the vulnerable always first, can genuinely help defend the livelihoods of the basin. This guide is an honest map of that careful, truthful path.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, adapted to a poor, contested, conflict-touched basin:

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION	(find the harm, the truth, and the framework)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION	(build the evidence -- the livelihoods and the science)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION	(build the community and the technical coalition)

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & TRANSBOUNDARY-GOVERNANCE (lake, scheme, oil)
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STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it a livelihoods-and-truth cause)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of the livelihoods and the honest science feeds the lake's defence, the scheme's scrutiny, and the oil accountability at once; the community and the technical experts organise carefully together; a livelihoods case, a scrutiny of the scheme, or an accountability claim is both pressure and a spur to the next. The effort that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still constrained — chance of defending the basin's livelihoods and scrutinising the harm.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Chad's — a poor, contested, transboundary, conflict-touched basin — give a distinctive set:

- **The lake's livelihoods.** The **fishing, farming, and herding** of millions can be defended through honest science and adaptation, not a risky fix — the distinctive lever.
- **The scheme's scrutiny.** The **grand Transaqua proposal** to divert Congo water can and must be rigorously scrutinised for its harms and its questionable premise.
- **The oil accountability.** The **oil and its broken revenue promises and community harms** can be held to account.
- **The frameworks.** The **transboundary lake and river frameworks** govern the shared waters and reach the schemes.
- **The humanitarian stake.** The **humanitarian crisis of the basin** reaches the world and its conscience.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers prevail, or that the lake is simply dying, or that the conditions are safe. The lake's story is **complex**; the poverty and conflict are **deep**; the nation is **poor and troubled**; and no victory is **final**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly, and it insists on honest science and scrutiny, not headlines — and shows how to use the real tools this situation offers — the lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, the oil accountability, the frameworks, and the humanitarian stake — to defend the basin's livelihoods and scrutinise the harm, honestly acknowledging the complexity, the poverty and conflict, the troubled conditions, and the unfinished work.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must see that the levers run through honest science, the scrutiny of grand fixes, and the transboundary frameworks, because in a poor, contested, conflict-touched basin the simple story is often wrong and the grand solution often risky, and the truth and the frameworks are where leverage lies. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides a project's fate, at which level, and where the leverage is real. And map where the lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, the oil accountability, the frameworks, and the humanitarian stake apply, because in Chad a destructive harm — or a destructive "solution" — is met not by accepting the headline, nor by open confrontation, which is dangerous, but by defending the livelihoods with honest science, scrutinising the grand scheme, and holding the oil to account through the frameworks.

The Levels of Decision

A Chadian environmental question runs through a poor, centralised, transboundary system.

The state and its agencies. The **transitional government, the water and environment ministries, and the oil authorities** decide and permit, and are the authority to be engaged — carefully — on the livelihoods, the science, and the frameworks.

The transboundary bodies. The **Lake Chad Basin Commission and the Congo basin authority** govern the shared waters and the grand scheme, and are where the transboundary case is pressed.

The scheme's backers and scrutineers. The **promoters of the grand scheme and the scientists and organisations who scrutinise it** are where the "solution" is contested.

The oil sector. The **oil companies and the revenue and oversight bodies** are where the oil's harms and broken promises are held to account.

The international and humanitarian partners. The **donors, the humanitarian agencies, the scientists, and the NGOs** carry the frameworks, the finance, and the standards that reach a poor, aid-dependent state.

The Journey of a Project

A Chadian question — a threat to the lake's livelihoods, a grand scheme to divert distant water, the oil's harm and broken promises — meets the **lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, the oil accountability, the frameworks, and the humanitarian stake**. The **lake's livelihoods and the scheme's scrutiny are where the harm is best met, and the frameworks and the humanitarian stake are what carry them** — and using them together, honestly, is the distinctive Chadian approach. The distinctive levers are the **lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, the oil accountability, the frameworks, and the humanitarian stake**. Find out exactly where the question stands, and, crucially, **what livelihoods, waters, or lands are at stake, what the honest science says, and how the frameworks and the scrutiny can be brought to bear**, because those are where a harm or a risky "solution" can genuinely be met.

Follow the Project, the Truth, and the Livelihood

Behind a project or a scheme stand the state, the promoters or the companies, and the livelihoods at stake. Trace who decides, who benefits, what is harmed, and — importantly here — **what the honest science actually says, whose livelihoods are threatened, what framework applies, and how the scrutiny and the partners can act**. Two questions unlock most Chadian efforts: **What is truly at stake, and what does the honest science say?** and **Which lever — the livelihoods, the scrutiny, the oil, the frameworks, the humanitarian stake — can meet it, carefully?** The lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, and the frameworks are, together, the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in a Chadian effort ultimately serves these: the documentation exists to establish the honest science and the livelihoods that ground the case; the community-and-framework coalition exists to press that case through the affected people, the scientists, and the partners; and the careful, international media exists to reach a poor, aid-dependent state and the world's conscience with the honest truth. Keep the lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, and the frameworks at the centre of every submission, claim, and appeal, and the effort retains a clear spine that runs from a single threatened livelihood or a single questionable premise to the honest defence of the basin's people and the careful scrutiny of the great decisions that shape their future.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a question, because they are the levers. The **transitional government, the water, environment, and oil authorities**; the **Lake Chad Basin Commission and the Congo basin authority**; the **scheme's backers and scrutineers**; the **oil sector and its oversight**; and

the **international and humanitarian partners**. In Chad, the **lake's livelihoods**, the **scheme's scrutiny**, the **oil accountability**, the **frameworks**, and the **humanitarian stake** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a separate front, and a harm to the livelihoods, a risky grand scheme, or the oil's broken promises can genuinely be pressed — through honest science, scrutiny, and the frameworks — though, honestly, the lake's story is complex, the poverty and conflict deep, the nation troubled, and no victory final, and this guide will keep saying so, and keep working carefully through truth, scrutiny, and the frameworks.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means acknowledging that the lake's story is complex, the poverty and conflict deep, and the conditions insecure, even as honest science, the scrutiny of grand fixes, and the frameworks give real leverage. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how environmental efforts tend to go in Chad and comparable poor, contested, conflict-touched basins, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the case can be **grounded in honest science and the livelihoods**, whether the **grand scheme can be rigorously scrutinised**, and whether the **transboundary frameworks and international partners** can be brought to bear. Where the science is honest and the frameworks engaged, the levers here are real; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the crisis is complex, the conditions insecure, and open confrontation dangerous.

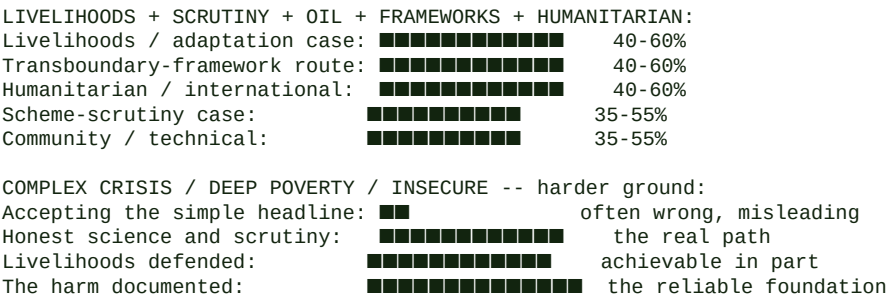
Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	15–25%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Livelihoods / adaptation case	40–60%	months–years	low	The livelihoods defended, adaptation supported
Scheme-scrutiny case	35–55%	years	low	The grand scheme rigorously assessed
Oil-accountability case	30–50%	years	low	The oil's harm and promises held to account
Transboundary-frame work route	40–60%	months–years	low	The lake and river frameworks engaged
Humanitarian / international	40–60%	months–years	low	The world's conscience and partners engaged
Community / technical	35–55%	months–years	low	The affected mobilised, the science marshalled
All levers together	35–55%	months–years	moderate	Livelihoods defended; harm and risky fix scrutinised

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Chad's real strengths are honest science, the scrutiny of grand fixes, and the frameworks: the **lake's livelihoods**, the **scheme's scrutiny**, the **oil accountability**, the **frameworks**, and the **humanitarian stake**. Its constraints are specific and honest: the lake's story is **complex**, the poverty and conflict **deep**, the nation **troubled**, and no victory **final** — so progress comes through truth, scrutiny, and the frameworks, carefully, not through headlines or open confrontation.

A note on cost and risk: most levers here — a livelihoods case, a scrutiny of the scheme, an accountability claim, an international framework — cost mainly organisation, knowledge, and care. But the risk is real: the region is insecure and conflict-touched, so the safety of those involved, especially vulnerable communities, must come first. The scarce resources are **the technical and scientific capacity, the international connections, and the careful navigation of a troubled land** — much of it reachable through the frameworks, the donors, and the humanitarian and scientific partners. This shapes where a Chadian effort should concentrate its energy. Because the decisive resources are honest scientific credibility, connection to the international and humanitarian frameworks and partners, and above all the judgement to navigate a troubled, insecure land safely — rather than the mass mobilisation that other struggles rely on and that here is dangerous — an effort's most valuable investments are in building scientific credibility, cultivating the international framework and partner relationships, and documenting the honest science and the livelihoods rigorously while keeping the vulnerable safe. A small, credible, well-connected effort that can marshal the honest science, defend the livelihoods, scrutinise the grand scheme, and enlist the international and humanitarian partners can accomplish a great deal in a poor, aid-dependent state, and can do so without exposing communities to danger. The resources that matter most are thus largely a matter of honest scientific credibility, connection, and careful judgement — much of it reachable through the international scientific, transboundary, and humanitarian frameworks and the donors and organisations that share a concern for the basin's people and its honest truth. And because the state is poor and aid-dependent and the science genuinely contested, the arguments grounded in honest science, the livelihoods, and the international frameworks are the most persuasive.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Chad are **the livelihoods and adaptation, the transboundary frameworks, and the humanitarian and international engagement** — used together, honestly. The livelihoods and framework levers show the ceiling: a case grounded in honest science, the livelihoods of millions, and the transboundary frameworks can defend the basin and scrutinise a risky fix. The complexity and the poverty and conflict show the honest floor: the crisis is tangled and the conditions hard. Most Chadian efforts will sit between, and the honest lesson is that the levers here are real — able to defend the livelihoods, scrutinise the scheme, hold the oil to account, and use the frameworks — but that accepting the simple headline is often misleading, and the surest result is that the livelihoods are defended and the harm and the risky "solution" honestly scrutinised.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The livelihoods and the transboundary frameworks** — Chad's distinctive strengths; the human stake and the shared-water standing.
2. **The scheme's scrutiny and the humanitarian stake** — the grand fix questioned and the world engaged.

3. **The honest science** — the accurate picture that grounds it all.
4. **The oil accountability** — the oil's harm and broken promises held to account.
5. **The documented harm** — the evidence of the livelihoods and the science that grounds it all.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **The lake's story is complex** — honest science, not the headline, is the ground. **The livelihoods are the stake** — the fishing, farming, and herding of millions unite and compel. **The grand scheme must be scrutinised** — a "solution" can be a harm. **The frameworks give standing** — the transboundary bodies govern the shared waters. **The humanitarian crisis reaches the world** — but the poverty and conflict are deep. The through-line: **ground the case in honest science; defend the livelihoods and support adaptation; scrutinise the grand scheme; hold the oil to account; use the transboundary frameworks and the humanitarian stake; and protect the vulnerable** — because an effort that does can genuinely defend the basin's livelihoods and scrutinise the harm, while being honest that the crisis is complex, the conditions insecure, and no victory final.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact question — and the leverage, which here runs through honest science, scrutiny, and the frameworks. Vague concern goes nowhere, and accepting the headline can mislead; an effort aimed at "this harm to these livelihoods, or this risky grand scheme, which the honest science, the scrutiny, and the frameworks can address" is a real, workable effort. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. **What is truly at stake?** This is the first question here. What **livelihoods, waters, or lands** are truly at stake — the lake's fishing, farming, and herding, the basin's water, the oil region's land and health.
2. **What does the honest science say?** What the **honest, accurate science** actually says — the lake's fluctuation, the scheme's likely impacts, the oil's harm — beyond the simple headline.
3. **Is the harm a project or a "solution"?** Whether the harm is a **destructive project** or a **destructive "solution"** — like a grand scheme whose cure may be worse than the ailment.
4. **What framework applies?** Which **transboundary lake or river framework, or oil-oversight framework** applies to the shared waters or the oil.
5. **How can the community and frameworks act, safely?** How the **affected communities, the technical experts, and the international partners** can act, carefully, protecting the vulnerable in a troubled land.

A Worked Example

Suppose a grand scheme to divert distant water is promoted to "save" the lake, on a questionable premise, with likely harm to another basin and to Chad's own lands, in place of honest adaptation to the lake's real fluctuation.

Working the five questions: **what is truly at stake? What does the honest science say? Is it a project or a "solution"? What framework applies?** And how can the community and frameworks act, safely? The driver is the grand scheme and its backers, with the honest science, the scrutiny, the frameworks, and the livelihoods as the levers.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the lake is dying and only the grand scheme can save it" to a real, honest effort: ground the case in the accurate science of the lake's fluctuation; scrutinise the scheme's premise, cost, and likely harms; defend the livelihoods and support adaptation; and engage the transboundary frameworks and partners — all carefully. That is a workable effort suited to Chad — one that scrutinises a risky "solution" and defends the livelihoods with honest science. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they suit a fight in a poor, contested, conflict-touched basin: they turn what might seem an impossible or hopeless situation — a lake said to be dying, a grand scheme said to be its only salvation, a poverty and conflict beyond remedy — into a set of specific, answerable questions, each attached to a lever that works through honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks rather than through a confrontation the conditions forbid or a headline the science contradicts. The stake becomes the livelihoods of millions. The truth becomes a matter of honest, accurate science. The scheme becomes a proposal to be rigorously assessed rather than accepted on alarm. The framework becomes the transboundary bodies that govern the shared waters. And the community and partners become the safe, effective channels. That translation — from a seemingly hopeless or headline-driven situation into a set of specific, honest actions that defend the livelihoods and scrutinise the harm through science and the frameworks — is the first and most important thing a Chadian effort does, because it moves the fight from the despair of a dying-lake myth and a tangled crisis onto the firm ground of honest science, the livelihoods, and transboundary law, where careful, truthful work is genuinely possible.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, distinctively, the decisive evidence is the honest science of the lake and the livelihoods at stake, and much of it exists in the research and the frameworks' own studies. A ministry, a transboundary body, a scientist, an international partner, and the public all move on evidence — and in Chad, a clear record grounded in honest science is precisely what a careful effort turns into a real result, so build it well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Question, the Truth, and the Livelihood

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **harm or the scheme** — the threat to the livelihoods, the grand diversion, the oil's harm — and, decisively here, **what the honest science says and whose livelihoods are at stake**: the lake's real fluctuation, the scheme's real premise and likely impacts, the oil's documented harm. Establish exactly **what is truly at stake and what the honest science says**, because the truth-and-the-livelihoods is the case's foundation, and honest science is the strongest ground in a contested basin.

Layer 2: The Science, the Impacts, and the Livelihoods

Document the case with the science. Establish the **honest science** — the lake's variability, the scheme's premise and likely environmental and social impacts, the oil's pollution and harm — and the **livelihoods** — the fishing, farming, and herding, and the humanitarian stakes — drawing on **the research, the transboundary bodies' studies, the frameworks' assessments, and the community's knowledge**. This science-and-livelihoods evidence turns the case into an honest, documented account of what is truly at stake, beyond the headline.

Layer 3: The Truth, the Framework, the Community, and the Care

Finally, document the case and the path. Does the **honest science** support the case, and does it expose a false premise or a risky "solution"? What **framework** — lake, river, or oil — applies? How will the **community and partners** act? And how will the **vulnerable be protected** in a troubled land? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case grounded in honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because an honest scientific case, a threatened livelihood, an applicable framework, and a careful, protected path are exactly what let a Chadian effort defend the basin and scrutinise the harm. Build it well, and the lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, the oil accountability, the frameworks, and the humanitarian stake become the effort's genuine strength. One practical note on building this layer: because Lake Chad, the grand diversion scheme, and the oil pipeline have all been genuine subjects of international scientific, institutional, and journalistic attention, a great deal of the necessary evidence already exists in research, assessments, and reporting, which spares an effort much of the burden of generating it in dangerous conditions and, crucially, provides the honest, independent science that is this effort's strongest ground. The lake's real fluctuation and the myth of its simple disappearance have been studied and documented; the grand scheme's questionable premise, its vast cost, and its likely impacts on the Congo basin and on Chad have been analysed by independent experts and organisations; the oil's revenue history and its community harms have been reported and recorded. This means an effort here can often build its file substantially from that existing, credible record, rather than having to generate contested new claims. Building this layer well therefore means seeking out and marshalling that existing scientific and institutional record — the lake studies, the scheme analyses, the oil-revenue history, the humanitarian assessments — and joining it to the community's own knowledge, so that the case rests on honest, independent, and largely-available evidence while keeping the vulnerable safe.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists — and here much of it lives in the scientific research, the transboundary bodies' studies, and the community's own knowledge. Here is where the material tends to live in a Chadian effort, and how to get it — with the **honest science**, the **livelihoods**, the **scheme**, and the **framework** at the center. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Question, Science, and Livelihood Record

Start with the honest science and the livelihoods. **The research, the frameworks' studies, and the livelihood picture** establish the truth and the stake; the distinctive strengths here are the **honest science** and the **livelihoods of millions**, both well studied. Establish the **honest science and whose livelihoods are at stake**, drawing on the research and the community. Establish exactly **what is truly at stake and what the science says**, because in a contested basin the honest science is the ground that a simple headline cannot shake.

The Science, Scheme, and Impacts Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather the **honest-science evidence** — the lake's real fluctuation and variability, the scheme's premise and likely impacts on the Congo basin and on Chad, the oil's pollution and harm — and the **livelihoods evidence** — the fishing, farming, and herding, the humanitarian stakes — drawing on **the scientific research, the transboundary bodies' studies, the independent assessments, and the community's knowledge**. This science-and-scheme evidence is what turns the case into an honest account that exposes false premises and risky "solutions."

The Framework and Transboundary Record

Document the levers of the frameworks. Gather the record of **the Lake Chad Basin Commission and the shared-lake governance**, and **the Congo basin authority and the shared-river governance** that the grand scheme would affect; and **the oil-revenue and oversight framework** and its history. A community that understands the lake, river, and oil frameworks holds the levers that reach the shared waters, the grand scheme, and the oil.

The International, Humanitarian, and Partner Record

Document the wider levers. Gather the record of the **international partners** — the donors, the scientists, the environmental and humanitarian organisations — who study the lake, scrutinise the scheme, and respond to the crisis; and the **humanitarian stake** — the displaced, the food-insecure, the millions in need. A community joined to the international and humanitarian partners holds levers that reach a poor, aid-dependent, crisis-touched state and the world's conscience.

The People, the Care, and the Protection

Finally, map the human terrain and the careful path, which here is a matter of safety. Who is affected — the **fishing, farming, and herding communities, the oil-region communities, the displaced, and the food-insecure** — and who can act: the **technical experts, the international partners, and the community**, carefully. And how does the effort **protect the vulnerable and navigate a troubled, insecure land**? A Chadian effort is advanced through honest science, the livelihoods, the scrutiny, the frameworks, and the humanitarian stake, with the greatest care for safety — so map that coalition deliberately, and let the protection of the vulnerable and a realistic sense of the insecurity govern every step.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Here this step must be understood carefully, because Chad is under military rule and much of the region is touched by conflict and insecurity, so open, adversarial organising is constrained and, in many areas, dangerous, and the "opposition" that works joins the affected communities to the technical experts and the international partners, pressing through honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks, with the safety of the vulnerable first. The task is to build a community — of fishers, farmers, herders, and experts — that defends the basin's livelihoods and scrutinises the harm, carefully, protecting all involved.

Why the Community-and-Framework Coalition Is Decisive

In Chad, the community that can act joins the affected people to the technical experts and the international frameworks, because a poor, troubled, aid-dependent state responds to honest science, the livelihoods, and the world's frameworks more than to open dissent, which the conditions make dangerous. That coalition supplies what a careful effort runs on: the affected communities who hold the knowledge and the stake, the technical experts whose honest science carries weight, and — distinctively — the international frameworks and partners for whom the lake, the Congo, and the humanitarian crisis are shared concerns. When affected communities, experts, and partners press with honest science, they become a genuine force. **A coalition that joins the affected communities to the experts and the international partners here is not a weaker substitute for open protest; it is the safer and more effective form advocacy can take in a troubled Chad — the real foundation of an effort, defending the livelihoods and scrutinising the harm through honest science, the frameworks, and care.** This is worth dwelling on, because the particular conditions of Chad make this careful, science-based, coalition approach not a fallback but the genuinely effective and responsible one. In a stable, open society, an environmental effort might rest on mass mobilisation and open

protest; in a nation under military rule and touched by conflict, where much of the land is insecure and speaking out can be dangerous, that avenue is both constrained and perilous, and its reckless pursuit could endanger the very communities it means to help. But Chad's situation offers a different strength: the questions here — the honest truth of the lake, the wisdom of a grand scheme, the fate of the oil's revenue — are matters of science, of transboundary law, and of the livelihoods of millions, all of which can be pressed through technical, institutional, and international channels rather than through confrontation. The task, therefore, is to build the coalition that joins the local and the global: the affected communities' knowledge and testimony, the scientists' honest evidence, and the international frameworks' standards and the world's humanitarian concern. This is not a weaker path but, in Chad's conditions, the wiser and safer one, for it advances the honest defence of the basin's livelihoods and the scrutiny of a risky fix through channels that carry weight without exposing the vulnerable to the dangers that open confrontation would bring.

Finding the Community

Begin with those the question touches and those who can act — the **fishing, farming, and herding communities, the oil-region communities, the technical experts, and the international partners** — and treat the insecurity with the utmost seriousness, protecting everyone involved. Widen with care to all who share the lake, the basin, and the livelihoods. Name the shared stake — **our lake, our fish, our herds, our lands, and our children's future** — because the lake and the basin are the life and food of millions. Frame the effort around honest science, the livelihoods, and the scrutiny of grand schemes, not around confrontation. There is real power, and real safety, in framing the cause this way, because it grounds the effort in truth and in stakes that unite rather than divide. A campaign framed as confrontation with the authorities or the scheme's powerful backers would be dangerous in a military-ruled, insecure land, and would invite repression. A campaign framed around the honest science of the lake, the livelihoods of the millions who fish and farm and herd by it, and the wisdom of scrutinising a grand and risky fix casts the effort not as opposition but as the honest defence of the basin's people and the careful testing of a great decision — a cause that fishers, scientists, and officials alike can engage, and that the state and the international partners find hard to reject. This framing is not only safer; it is also truer, because the real stake genuinely is the livelihoods and the honest truth, and the aim genuinely is to defend and to scrutinise, not to confront or to accept a myth. An effort that names this stake precisely — honest science, the livelihoods, and the scrutiny of grand schemes — stands on the broadest, safest, and most truthful ground the Chadian situation affords.

Coalition-Building, Through Community and Frameworks

A coalition allied is stronger than a community alone, and in Chad it runs through the community, the experts, and the frameworks. Reach, with care, to the **affected communities; the technical and scientific experts; the transboundary bodies and their scientists; the international and humanitarian partners and NGOs**. Frame the coalition around the lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, the oil accountability, and the frameworks. Build breadth carefully, favouring the community and international routes over confrontation, and protecting the vulnerable in a troubled land.

Sustaining the Effort

Chadian efforts are sustained through honest science, the livelihoods, the frameworks, and care. Keep the community **informed, connected, and safe**; mark real steps — a livelihood defended, a scheme scrutinised, an assessment forced, an oil harm addressed, a framework strengthened. And keep the effort grounded in honest science and the livelihoods, which unite and endure. The effort that lasts is the one that joins the affected communities to the experts and the partners, presses honest science and the livelihoods,

and works carefully through the channels that are safe.

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & TRANSBOUNDARY-GOVERNANCE CHALLENGES — THE LAKE'S LIVELIHOODS, THE SCHEME'S SCRUTINY, AND THE OIL ACCOUNTABILITY

This is where a Chadian effort is realistically advanced — not through accepting the headline, nor through open confrontation, which is dangerous, but through the **defence of the lake's livelihoods, the scrutiny of the grand scheme, and the accountability for the oil**, grounded in honest science and the transboundary frameworks. Here the livelihoods, scrutiny, and oil levers come together, because in Chad a harm to the livelihoods, a risky grand "solution," or the oil's broken promises can be pressed through those levers, carefully.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The levers are **real but work within a poor, troubled, contested basin**. The livelihoods case is **strong but the crisis is tangled**; the scheme's scrutiny is **vital but the backers are powerful**; the oil accountability is **just but the state is dependent on the oil**; and the science is **contested**. What these levers realistically achieve is **the livelihoods defended, adaptation supported, the scheme rigorously assessed, the oil held to account, and the frameworks strengthened** — real outcomes, if not the resolution of a tangled crisis. Enter this front clear-eyed: the lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, and the oil accountability are Chad's distinctive levers, strongest when **grounded in honest science and the transboundary frameworks** — but the crisis is complex, the backers powerful, and the conditions insecure.

The Lake's Livelihoods and the Honest Science

The first front is the livelihoods and the truth. The **lake's fishing, farming, and herding** sustain millions, and the honest science — that the lake fluctuates and is not simply vanishing, and that its communities have long adapted — is the ground for defending those livelihoods through **sustainable management, adaptation, and diversification** rather than dependence on a single risky fix, pursued through the **Lake Chad Basin Commission** and the transboundary framework. Use the livelihoods and the honest science together, because the human stake and the accurate picture are the case's core, and a defence grounded in truth is stronger than one built on a headline. Insist that the basin's real needs — adaptation, sustainable management, diversified economies, and a strengthened transboundary body — be met, rather than staked on a single dramatic scheme. It is worth being clear about both the power and the limits of this livelihoods-and-science front, honestly, for it is the foundation on which a Chadian effort stands. Its power is real and distinctive: it rests on honest, independent science rather than on alarm, and on the livelihoods of millions rather than on abstraction, so it is both credible and humanly compelling, and it exposes the false premise on which a costly and risky grand scheme is being urged. Its limits are equally real: the honest science is more complex and less dramatic than the headline, and complexity persuades less easily than alarm; the poverty and the crisis are genuine and demand real responses, not merely the correction of a myth; and the backers of the grand scheme are powerful and their simple story appealing. Understanding both means using the livelihoods-and-science front for what it does best — grounding the whole effort in honest truth, defending the livelihoods, and pressing the real and less glamorous remedies of adaptation, sustainable management, and diversified economies — while recognising that honest complexity must be

communicated with care and patience, and paired with the concrete defence of the livelihoods, so that correcting the myth is never mistaken for denying the genuine crisis of the basin's people.

The Scheme's Scrutiny and the Transboundary Frameworks

The second front is the grand scheme. The **massive proposal to divert distant water** to "save" the lake rests on a questionable premise, would carry vast environmental and social risks to another basin and to Chad's own lands, and is driven in part by private and political interests, so subjecting it to **rigorous, independent environmental and social assessment**, through the **transboundary frameworks of both basins** and the requirement to consult and protect the affected — including the downstream basin — is a genuine and vital lever, because a "solution" of this scale can be a great harm. Press the scheme's scrutiny and the transboundary frameworks, because a grand fix must be proven, assessed, and consented to, not accepted on alarm and the promise of a silver bullet.

The Oil Accountability and the Humanitarian Stake

The third front is the oil and the world. The **oil and its pipeline** were once a famous experiment in turning oil money to the people's good — an experiment that failed when the revenue safeguards were undone — and its extraction has brought pollution and community grievances, so pressing **transparency, accountability, community benefit, and remediation** for the oil is a genuine lever, grounded in the revenue and oversight frameworks and the communities' rights. And the **humanitarian stake** — the displaced, the food-insecure, the millions in need — reaches the world's conscience and its partners. Pursued together — the lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, the oil accountability, the transboundary frameworks, and the humanitarian stake — these fronts are how a Chadian effort defends the basin and scrutinises the harm, through honest science, the frameworks, and care. It is worth understanding why these fronts reinforce one another so well in Chad's particular situation. The livelihoods case, grounded in honest science, supplies the human stake and the accurate picture that a mere headline cannot. The scheme's scrutiny supplies the vital testing of a grand fix that could, on a false premise, do great harm. The oil accountability supplies the demand for transparency and benefit that the oil's own broken history invites. And the transboundary frameworks and humanitarian stake supply the shared-water standing and the world's concern that reach a poor, aid-dependent state. Each covers the others' limits: the livelihoods where the human stake compels, the scrutiny where a grand fix must be tested, the oil accountability where extraction's harms must be answered, and the frameworks where transboundary standing and the world's conscience help. An effort that grasps this division of labour, and pursues each front together and carefully, makes the fullest use of the several levers that a poor, contested, transboundary, conflict-touched basin uniquely provides, while keeping the honest science and the safety of the vulnerable at the centre throughout.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them. The same file of honest science and livelihoods becomes different arguments for the state, the transboundary bodies, the scheme's backers, the oil sector, and the world. Translate deliberately, and always grounded in honest science.

For the State and Its Agencies

The state responds to **the livelihoods, the frameworks, and its dependence on aid and oil**. Frame the case as the defence of the livelihoods of millions and the sound management of the basin: here is the honest science, the livelihoods, the frameworks, the risky scheme, the oil. Give them the honest science and

the livelihoods, and press for sustainable management, rigorous assessment, and accountability. Make it concrete: *here is what the science really says, here is what protects the livelihoods, here is the framework.* This is the argument a poor, aid-dependent state must weigh.

For the Transboundary Bodies

The transboundary bodies respond to **the shared waters, the science, and their mandate**. Frame the case as a matter of the shared lake and river: here is the honest science, the transboundary impact, the requirement to assess and consult. Give them the science and the frameworks, and press for sustainable management and rigorous assessment of the scheme. A transboundary body charged with the shared waters can defend the basin and scrutinise the scheme.

For the Scheme's Backers

The scheme's backers respond to **the assessment, the cost, the risk, and their reputation**. Frame the case as a demand for proof and scrutiny: here is the questionable premise, the vast risk, the harm to another basin, the need for rigorous, independent assessment and consent. Give them the science and the risks, and press for genuine assessment before any commitment. Backers pressed to prove and assess a grand scheme must reckon with its risks.

For the Public and the World

The public and the world respond to **the livelihoods, the truth, and the humanitarian stakes**. Translate the file into a story anyone can grasp: here are the livelihoods of millions, the honest truth of a complex crisis, the risk of a grand fix that could do harm. Frame it as the honest defence of the basin's livelihoods and the scrutiny of a risky scheme. Keep it accurate and careful; and protect the vulnerable, for in a troubled land the affected must not be endangered. And speak to the shared basin and the world's conscience.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never accept a false headline, never demand the impossible, and protect the vulnerable above all. Your credibility rests on the honest science, the real livelihoods, and the genuine risks — truth and scrutiny, not alarm or confrontation; and safety is paramount in a troubled land. State the case precisely and honestly, tie it to the science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks, and press carefully through the community and the partners. An effort that is precise, honest, and grounded in science and livelihoods is far harder to dismiss than one that overreaches or accepts a myth, and far safer than one that courts confrontation in an insecure land.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — and here, in a troubled, military-ruled land, the domestic space is constrained and can be dangerous, so the "media" that works is careful, honest documentation and the international channels that reach a poor, aid-dependent state and the world's conscience. The story — the livelihoods of millions, the honest truth of a complex crisis, the risk of a grand fix — resonates, if told carefully, honestly, and safely.

Why Media Matters

The state, the transboundary bodies, the scheme's backers, the oil sector, and the world behave differently when the honest science and the livelihoods are visible. Media does three things here: it **connects the affected communities to the technical and partner world**, it **raises the stakes** for a state mindful of its

aid and its standing, and it **reaches the international and humanitarian partners and the world's conscience**. But Chad is troubled and insecure, with a constrained press, so the media effort runs largely through **international scientific, environmental, and humanitarian media, the frameworks' channels, and careful, honest documentation**, protecting the vulnerable, rather than confrontational domestic press.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the truth and the livelihoods. The strongest frame is honest and human: *the lake is not simply dying as the headlines say, but the livelihoods of millions are genuinely at stake in a complex crisis — and a grand scheme proposed to save it may do great harm*. Put the honest truth and the livelihoods first, because accuracy is the ground and the livelihoods reach and unite. Keep it scrupulously accurate; and never endanger the affected or accept a myth. The Chadian story is powerful precisely because it is honest about a complex crisis that the simple headline distorts. This is the heart of the matter, and it is worth stating plainly why it gives a Chadian effort its distinctive force. The power of the case lies not in a dramatic alarm, which the honest science does not support, but in the truth of a complex crisis and the real stake of the livelihoods of millions: it is a lake that fluctuates rather than dies, a people whose fishing and farming and herding genuinely hang in the balance, and a grand scheme urged upon them that could, on a false premise, do great harm. An effort that traded in the dramatic myth would be both dishonest and, in the end, easily discredited. An effort that holds up the honest truth of the lake, the real livelihoods of its people, and the genuine risks of a grand fix asks only that the truth be faced and the people's livelihoods defended, which is a stake that honest science and the world's conscience are bound to respect, and which the transboundary frameworks exist precisely to serve. That is why the honest truth of a complex crisis, joined to the livelihoods of millions and the world's frameworks, is the strategic core of the entire Chadian approach, and the reason that careful, truthful work can help even in a poor and troubled basin.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience, and to the danger. **International scientific, environmental, and humanitarian media** for the world and the partners; **the transboundary frameworks' channels** for the shared waters and the scheme; **technical and scientific publication** for the honest science; and **careful, protected documentation** for the record. Because the domestic space is constrained and insecure, the international and framework channels matter most, and the safety of the affected comes first — the honest truth of a complex crisis and the risk of a grand fix is the story's careful power.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, honest, careful, and safe — the aim is truth, the livelihoods, and scrutiny, not alarm or endangering anyone. Frame the story around the honest science, the livelihoods, and the scrutiny, and be mindful of the insecurity and the sensitivities of a military-ruled, conflict-touched land. Handle the government, the security situation, the conflict, the refugees, and the foreign and regional dimensions factually and with care, protecting the vulnerable. And sustain the story through the ongoing crisis. Above all, let the honest truth of a complex crisis and the real stake of the livelihoods carry the story, because that is where a Chadian effort is strongest, and let safety govern always.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real question, the honest science, and the real livelihoods, keep it factual and careful, protect the vulnerable, and ground everything in truth. Here the honest science, and the livelihoods, win.

8A: Requesting Information

Subject: Request for information — [scheme / project] and its impact on the basin

To [ministry / transboundary body / authority],

I am writing on behalf of [community / group] regarding [the scheme / project] and its effects on [the lake / the basin / our livelihoods]. To understand and respond, we respectfully request the **environmental and social assessments**, the **scientific studies and data**, and the **relevant plans and frameworks** for the question. We wish to protect the livelihoods our communities depend on, grounded in honest science.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8B: The Livelihoods and Honest-Science Case

Subject: Defending our livelihoods with honest science at [location]

To [water / environment ministry / transboundary body],

The fishing, farming, and herding of our communities depend on the lake, whose honest science shows it fluctuates rather than simply vanishing. We respectfully urge that the basin's real needs — sustainable management, adaptation, and diversified livelihoods — be met, grounded in accurate science, rather than staked on a single risky fix. We attach the science and the livelihood evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8C: Scrutinising the Grand Scheme

Subject: Rigorous assessment of [the diversion scheme]

To [transboundary body / authority],

The grand scheme to divert distant water to the lake rests on a questionable premise and would carry vast environmental and social risks to another basin and to our own lands. We respectfully urge that it be subjected to rigorous, independent environmental and social assessment, and to the consent of all affected, through the transboundary frameworks, before any commitment. We attach the concerns and the science.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8D: The Oil-Accountability Case

Subject: Accountability and remediation for the oil at [location]

To [oil / environment authority],

The oil at [location] has brought pollution and grievances to our communities, and the promises once made to turn its revenue to the people's good were not kept. We respectfully urge transparency, accountability, remediation of the harm, and a fair share of the benefit for the affected communities, in keeping with the revenue and oversight frameworks. We attach the evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8E: To an International or Humanitarian Partner

Subject: Support for the basin's livelihoods and honest science

Dear [partner / donor / organisation],

We write regarding [the threat / the scheme] affecting the livelihoods of millions in the Lake Chad basin, and the honest science of a complex crisis. We respectfully seek your support in defending the livelihoods, scrutinising the grand scheme, and grounding the response in accurate science, in keeping with the frameworks and standards you uphold. We provide the documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8F: To the Transboundary Bodies

Subject: Sustainable management of our shared waters

To [Lake Chad Basin Commission / Congo basin authority],

The shared waters of our basin sustain millions, and the grand scheme and the pressures upon them require sound, transboundary, science-based management. We respectfully urge sustainable management, rigorous assessment of the scheme, and the protection of the livelihoods and the affected basins. We attach the science and the assessments.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8G: Media / Documentation Pitch

Subject: The honest truth of Lake Chad, and a grand fix that may do harm

Dear [journalist / editor],

The story of Lake Chad is more complex than the headlines: the lake is not simply dying, but the livelihoods of millions are genuinely at stake, and a grand scheme proposed to save it may do great harm. There is an honest, important story here, and we can provide the science, the community's voices, and an account told with care for the safety of those involved.

Sincerely,

[Name, group, contact]

8H: Rallying the Community

Subject: Our lake, our livelihoods, our future — let us defend them honestly

Dear neighbours,

The lake that feeds us is not simply dying, but our livelihoods are genuinely at stake, and a grand scheme is proposed that may do us harm. Together — fishers, farmers, herders, and all who share the basin — by grounding our case in honest science, defending our livelihoods, scrutinising the scheme, and using the

frameworks, we can defend our basin and its livelihoods, carefully and safely. Please join us, with care: share what you know, and add your voice.

With respect,

[Name, group]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a question is acute — a grand scheme advancing to commitment, an oil harm spreading, a livelihood collapsing, a false alarm driving a rushed decision — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest and most safely here, which means the honest science, the livelihoods, and the international frameworks, protecting the vulnerable.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials: **what is truly at stake, and what the honest science says**. Identify the immediate question — **a scheme nearing commitment, an oil harm, a collapsing livelihood, a rushed decision** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach the **affected community, the technical experts, and the international partners** at once, because in Chad the honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks are the fastest routes to real leverage — and protect the vulnerable from the start, for the conditions are insecure.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **The honest-science correction** can be made at once, countering a false alarm. **The livelihoods case** can be raised immediately, uniting the affected. **The demand for rigorous assessment** can be pressed at once against a rushed scheme. **The international and humanitarian partners** can be engaged quickly. These outpace the slower work of the transboundary reform and the oil accountability — which must follow — because the honest science, the livelihoods, and the assessment demand can be brought to bear immediately. Above all, if a grand scheme nears commitment on a false premise, press the honest science and the demand for assessment fast, because a rushed grand fix is hardest to undo once begun.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but here you can reach the community and partners fast, with care. Reach immediately to the **affected community, the technical experts, and the international partners**, protecting the vulnerable. A coalition grounding the case in honest science, defending the livelihoods, and demanding assessment is the most a rapid Chadian effort can do, safely. Speed favours the prepared: know the honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks before the crisis breaks, and work carefully, protecting all involved.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the field is tilted by the complexity of the crisis, by the deep poverty and the long conflict, by military rule and insecurity across much of the land, by the powerful interests behind the grand scheme and the oil, and by the contested and often distorted science. Name it plainly, because pretending the crisis is simple, or that the interests are weak, or that the conditions are safe, would be false — but the honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks make even this tilted field one where careful, truthful work can

help.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific and honest. **The crisis is complex** — a tangle of climate, poverty, and conflict, not a simple lake dying. **The poverty and conflict are deep** — beyond easy remedy. **The land is troubled and insecure** — military rule and conflict constrain and endanger. **And powerful interests and distorted science weigh** — the scheme's backers and the oil interests are strong, and the science is contested. But **the honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks** are real and unifying. This is a tilt of complexity, poverty, insecurity, and distortion, worked through honest science, the livelihoods, the scrutiny, and the frameworks, carefully, not through headlines or open confrontation.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted, use the levers of truth, the livelihoods, and the frameworks. Lean on the **honest science**, which counters distortion; the **livelihoods**, which unite; the **scrutiny of the scheme**, which tests a grand fix; the **transboundary frameworks**, which govern the shared waters; and the **international and humanitarian partners**, which reach a poor state. Meet the grand scheme not with alarm but with the demand for honest assessment and consent, and the oil not with confrontation but with the demand for accountability. And build the scientific record and the international relationships over time, because in a poor, aid-dependent state these accumulate into influence. A field tilted by complexity, poverty, and distortion is worked through honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks, with the greatest care for the vulnerable, not through confrontation the conditions make dangerous.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may achieve little visible change — the scheme may advance, the oil's harm may go on, the livelihoods may erode — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the interests are powerful and the conditions hard. But here the work is rarely wholly wasted: the **honest science was established, the livelihoods were defended, the scheme was scrutinised, the oil was held to account, and the frameworks were engaged** — and every false alarm corrected, every livelihood defended, every rigorous assessment forced, every framework strengthened makes a real difference to the basin and its people. Press, carefully, for truth and the livelihoods; even if a scheme advances, the honest science you established and the scrutiny you pressed will shape the next decision, because a grand fix built on a false premise and a basin's livelihoods at stake are matters that honest science cannot forever be kept from.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In Chad, alongside the honest complexity of the crisis, there can be a concern of poor governance in the oil and the grand schemes: revenue diverted from its promised purpose, deals struck opaquely, and the wealth and the great projects of the nation not serving its people. Indeed the oil's own history — the undoing of the safeguards meant to turn its revenue to the people's good — is a documented example. This must be approached with great care in an insecure, military-ruled land, and the safer, more effective route runs through the international frameworks, the transparency standards, and the honest science.

Telling Capture from the Ordinary Tilt

In many resource-touched, troubled states there is a line between the ordinary tilt of a poor economy and the capture of its wealth and projects by the few. The marks are specific: **revenue diverted from its promised purpose, oil and scheme deals struck without transparency, great projects serving private**

and political interests, and the wealth of the land not serving its people. Be rigorous and careful: **distinguish the ordinary hardship and complexity from provable, documented capture**, and rely on the international transparency frameworks, the revenue and oversight standards, and the honest science, because in an insecure land these are safer and more credible than accusation. And note that the capture of the oil's revenue and the grand schemes deprives the very people whose livelihoods are at stake.

Responding to Capture — Through the Frameworks, Carefully

Where capture is real, the response runs through the international frameworks and the careful, protected channels. Use the **international transparency frameworks** for the oil and resource revenue to press for openness. Use the **revenue and oversight standards** and the oil's own documented history to hold the harm to account. Use the **honest science and the assessment requirements** to expose a grand scheme captured by private or political interests. And use the **international partners and donors** who support transparency and honest science. Document carefully and protect everyone involved, for in an insecure land the record must be rigorous and the people shielded. Route the effort through the frameworks, the transparency standards, and the honest science — never through open confrontation, which the conditions make dangerous.

A Note on Safety and Care

This note matters most of all here. Chad is under military rule and much of the region is touched by conflict, insecurity, armed groups, and a great refugee crisis, with real dangers to those who speak out, so this work must be done with the greatest care. Favour the **community, technical, and international channels** over open confrontation; protect individuals absolutely, especially the vulnerable fishing, farming, herding, and displaced communities and any local advocates who could be endangered; frame the work around honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks, not around challenging authority; avoid the conflict zones and the armed actors entirely; and handle the government, the security situation, the conflict, the refugees, and the sensitive matters factually and with the utmost discretion. Care here is not caution but necessity: the effective and safe path in Chad runs through honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks, and any straying into confrontation or into danger could cost vulnerable people gravely while achieving less than careful work through the frameworks and the community.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others — all through honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks, with care. Here is how they fit into a single, careful Chadian effort.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together. **Documentation** builds the honest-science-and-livelihoods file. **Target identification** aims it at the levers. **Local opposition**, understood as the community-and-framework coalition, organises the affected people, the experts, and the partners, carefully. **Legal, regulatory, and transboundary-governance** work presses the livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, and the oil accountability. **Media**, largely international and honest, carries the livelihoods-and-truth cause. The honest-science-and-livelihoods feeds all five at once — a documented, accurate case is a livelihoods defence, a scheme scrutiny, an oil accountability, and a framework claim together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, joining community, experts, and frameworks, they

compound into the honest defence of the basin's livelihoods.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the honest science and the livelihoods; identify the scheme, the oil, and the frameworks; build the community-and-framework coalition and begin documentation, protecting the vulnerable. **Middle (months 2–18):** defend the livelihoods and press adaptation; scrutinise the grand scheme through the frameworks; press the oil accountability; and engage the international and humanitarian partners. **Later (months and years):** see the livelihoods defended, the scheme rigorously assessed, the oil held to account, and the frameworks strengthened. A Chadian effort works through honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks, and its fruits — defended livelihoods, honest assessment, accountability — are gradual; pace it accordingly, and let the protection of the vulnerable govern every step.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **ground the case in honest science; defend the livelihoods and support adaptation; scrutinise the grand scheme; hold the oil to account; use the transboundary frameworks and the humanitarian stake; and protect the vulnerable.** The coalition that presses all five, joining community, experts, and frameworks, grounded in honest science and protecting the vulnerable, is the one that can genuinely defend the basin's livelihoods and scrutinise the harm — the kind of result a poor, troubled, contested basin allows.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing a destructive project — or a destructive "solution" — in Chad is genuinely difficult, and bound up with the complexity of the crisis, with the deep poverty and the long conflict, with military rule and insecurity, and with powerful interests and contested science, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: the lake's story is complex, the poverty and conflict deep, the nation troubled, and no victory final. And yet the effort is far from futile, because the lake's livelihoods can be defended through honest science and adaptation rather than a risky fix, because a grand scheme can and must be rigorously scrutinised, because the oil's harm and broken promises can be held to account, because the lake and the Congo are governed by transboundary frameworks, and because the humanitarian stakes reach the whole world — and those levers of the lake's livelihoods, the scheme's scrutiny, the oil accountability, the frameworks, and the humanitarian stake are real.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **The lake is not simply dying — honest science, not the headline, is the ground. The livelihoods of millions are the true and unifying stake. A grand scheme proposed to save the lake may itself do great harm, and must be scrutinised. But the crisis is complex, the interests powerful, and the conditions insecure.** Hold both truths at once: real, distinctive levers of honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks, and the honest weight of a complex, poor, troubled, contested basin.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the care — that give these efforts their force. Ground the case in honest science. Defend the livelihoods and support adaptation. Scrutinise the grand scheme. Hold the oil to account. Use the transboundary frameworks and the humanitarian stake. And protect the vulnerable — because in a poor, troubled basin whose truth is contested, an effort that defends the livelihoods and scrutinises the harm through honest science, the frameworks, and the world's conscience, carried carefully and protecting those who act, is the one that is both effective and just.

Chad sits at the heart of a great transboundary basin, around a lake that once ranked among the largest in the world and shrank, in the droughts of two harsh decades, to a fraction of its size — a lake that became a symbol of a dying world, though the honest truth is subtler: it fluctuates and endures, and the real crisis is the tangle of variable water, deep poverty, and long conflict that grips the millions who live by it. This guide has hidden none of that, nor accepted the simple headline, nor pretended that a grand scheme will save the lake, or that the conditions are safe, and there is no landmark victory to promise you. But the livelihoods of those millions are a stake that honest science and the world's conscience can defend, and the levers are real: the honest science that corrects the myth and grounds the case, the scrutiny that tests a grand and risky fix, the accountability that the oil's broken promises invite, the transboundary frameworks that govern the shared waters, and the humanitarian stake that reaches the world. There is no simple rescue for a complex crisis, and no easy opposition in a troubled land; this guide has said so throughout, and insisted above all on the safety of those who act. But the lake and basin and people of Chad are worth every careful, honest effort, the levers that run through truth, scrutiny, and the frameworks are real, and the patient, careful, truthful work of grounding the case in honest science, defending the livelihoods, and scrutinising the grand fix is one that Chadians and their allies can genuinely do — and, carefully and honestly, defend the livelihoods of the basin. So can you.